Kashmir] ... Personally, I do not think we should be under any illusion about this matter. I think Iranians will definitely support the Pakistanis'.[67]

Thirdly, the 1970s saw major political upheaval within Kabul. In 1973, much to India's surprise, Zahir Shah was ousted in a bloodless coup by his cousin and former PM Mohammad Daud Khan. Ambitious, virulently anti-Pakistan, and close to the Soviet Union, Daud saw the monarchy as an ancient political system unsuitable for twentieth-century Afghanistan.[68] He wanted to usher in socialist reforms, and take a stronger line against Pakistan (and Iran), unlike the politically mild king. With Moscow backing the plan, Daud struck on 17 July 1973, while Zahir Shah was vacationing in Italy. Rejected by the Khalq (which had become an important political force by the early 1970s), Daud entered into an alliance with Parcham in order to orchestrate the coup. Daud's post-coup modernisation drive in conservative Afghanistan helped the Khalq become widely popular at his expense. Despite being viewed as a secular-socialist politician internationally, Daud's radical domestic reforms, anti-Pakistan rhetoric, and increasing emphasis on the Pashtunistan issue only made things worse. In April 1974, US diplomats in Kabul began raising concerns about Daud's activism on Pashtunistan and intensive efforts to cultivate closer 'military' ties with India as an alternative to Kabul's then 'total reliance on Soviet training and supply'.[69] By November 1974, Kabul had begun a massive military build-up along the Pakistan border with a promise of more Soviet military support including 1,170 tanks (including the T-62, T-54, and T-55, and bridge-laying tanks), over 6,000 pieces of artillery (including 500 each of SAM-7 and SAM-2 missiles), transport vehicles, infantry equipment, radars, forty Mig-21s and forty Mig-27 aircraft, and combat helicopters.[70]

India's response to this change of guard in Kabul was mixed. The Indian embassy in Kabul gave conflicting reports about the coup and its sustainability. S. K. Singh, India's ambassador to Afghanistan in 1973 (who later became foreign secretary and ignored Assadullah Sarwari's pleas in 1990), was of the opinion that Daud's regime would be stable and, with popular support, sustainable.[71] Given Daud's unambiguous stand on Pakistan and Kashmir, Singh viewed him as a welcome change in India's favour. However, for J. Daulet Singh, India's political counselor in Kabul, the coup reeked of a brewing turmoil. Given Daud's forceful